

Massachusetts Cultural Resource Information System

Scanned Record Cover Page

Inventory No:	WHI.283
Historic Name:	Gurney, Jonathan Reed and Deborah C. Reed House
Address:	364 Franklin St
City/Town:	Whitman
Village/Neighborhood:	
Local No:	
Year Constructed:	C 1816
Architectural Style(s):	Federal;
Use(s):	Single Family Dwelling House;
Significance:	Architecture;
Area(s):	
Designation(s):	
Building Materials:	Roof: Asphalt Shingle; Wall: Wood; Wood Clapboard; Wood Shingle; Foundation: Granite; Stone, Cut;
Demolished	No



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Commonwealth of Massachusetts
Massachusetts Historical Commission
220 Morrissey Boulevard, Boston, Massachusetts 02125
www.sec.state.ma.us/mhc

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FORM B – BUILDING

MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION
 MASSACHUSETTS ARCHIVES BUILDING
 220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD
 BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

31A-124-37

Whitman

WHI.283

Town/City: Whitman**Place:** (*neighborhood or village*):**Address:** 364 Franklin Street**Historic Name:** Jonathan R. Gurney House**Uses:** Present: Dwelling

Original: Dwelling

Date of Construction: Possibly ca. 1816**Source:** Marriage date**Style/Form:** Federal Cape**Architect/Builder:** Unknown**Exterior Material:**

Foundation: Granite block

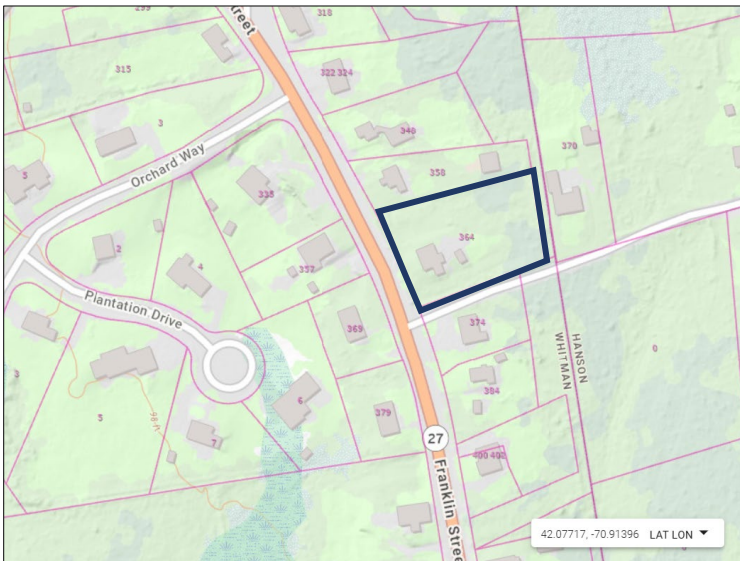
Wall/Trim: Wood clapboard & shingle / Wood

Roof: Asphalt shingle

Outbuildings/Secondary Structures:

Barn/garage

Sheds (2)

Photograph**Locus Map****Major Alterations** (*with dates*):

Windows boarded over

South block (20th c.)**Condition:** Poor - Fair**Moved:** no ☒ yes ☐ **Date:****Acreage:** 0.9

Setting: Moderately densely settled residential neighborhood on the far east side of Whitman. Former farmland developed in the late 19th through the early 20th centuries for housing to support local industries. Small to moderate-sized dwellings on generous lots with house forms ranging from Capes to Colonial Revival.

Recorded by: Lynn Smiledge**Organization:** Whitman Historical Commission**Date** (*month/year*): March 2025**RECEIVED****AUG 11 2025****MASS. HIST. COMM.**

INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

WHITMAN

364 FRANKLIN STREET

MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION

220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD, BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

Area(s)

Form No.

WHI.283

☐ Recommended for listing in the National Register of Historic Places.

If checked, you must attach a completed National Register Criteria Statement form.

Use as much space as necessary to complete the following entries, allowing text to flow onto additional continuation sheets.

ARCHITECTURAL DESCRIPTION:

Describe architectural features. Evaluate the characteristics of this building in terms of other buildings within the community.

The dwelling at **364 Franklin Street** occupies a trapezoidal lot on the east side of the street. The house is sited in the western quadrant of the parcel on a gentle knoll and faces west. The property is maintained in lawn bordered by tall pines and deciduous trees at the northern, eastern, and southern parcel boundaries and a hedge at the street. Uniform foundation plantings line the façade (west elevation). A paved driveway enters the property from Franklin Street at the approximate midpoint of the western lot line, travels past the north elevation of the house, and ends in an expanded parking area off the rear (west) elevation. A barn/garage structure is sited behind (east of) the southeast corner of the house.

This dwelling was constructed in the full Cape form in the early 19th century. It comprises a one-and-one-half-story, five-bay-by-two-bay main block with a one-story shed-roofed dependency at the south elevation. The house has a granite block foundation and an asphalt shingle roof. The walls are clad in wood clapboards at the façade and wood shingles at all other elevations. A narrow brick replacement chimney is centered at the roof ridge of the main block.

Trim elements at the main block comprise corner and frieze boards. Apart from paired two-over-two sash at the second story at the north elevation and paired one-over-one sash at the second story at the south elevation, the windows are boarded over. The openings have flat wood surrounds. The main entry centered at the façade contains a batten door with strap hinges framed by a narrow flat surround. The door fronts a railed wooden stoop and step that descends to a small, paved landing at the lawn. The shed-roofed south block extends from the west bay of the south elevation and contains contemporary fenestration; it replaced a flat-roofed enclosed porch seen in a mid-20th century photograph of the house (see image below).

The Cape Cod house form, a one-story side-gabled house with a central chimney and steeply-pitched roof, emerged in southeastern New England ca. 1700 and saw continued use through the mid-19th century. The full Cape design was one of the later iterations of the house type. Defining characteristics of the Cape style illustrated in this house include the full Cape configuration (five bays with a center entry), side-gabled roof, and center chimney in alignment with the entry. The quarry-cut granite block foundation is characteristic of late 18th/early 19th century construction. The two-over-two window sash configuration seen at the north elevation is a late 19th/early 20th century feature.

HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

Discuss the history of the building. Explain its associations with local (or state) history. Include uses of the building, and the role(s) the owners/occupants played within the community.

The town of Whitman in southeastern Massachusetts, originally settled in the northern part of Bridgewater, became part of the town of Abington in 1712. In 1875 the area separated from Abington and was designated South Abington. In 1886 the citizens changed the name of the town to Whitman after one of its prominent families. Agriculture was the basis of the town's economy during its formative years, but only dairy farming persisted into the 20th century. By the early 19th century Whitman's economy was primarily driven by the tack making and lumbering industries. The lumber was used for shipbuilding and wooden box manufacturing. The mid-19th century saw the establishment of boot and shoe factories and ancillary businesses, which soon dominated the local economy. Other products manufactured in Whitman included coffins, packing boxes, and nails. The town is remembered for its early mustering of troops to serve in the Union Army. Whitman's company was the first in the state to report fully equipped for duty at the outset of the Civil War. The town is also associated with the creation of the Toll House cookie in the 1930s by Ruth Wakefield, the owner of the Toll House Restaurant.

Franklin Street runs north-south in the far eastern side of Whitman close to the Hanson town line. The earliest recorded conveyance found for this property in a clear chain of ownership was its sale by Elizabeth F. (Lizzie) Perry to Eliza Moore in

Continuation sheet 1

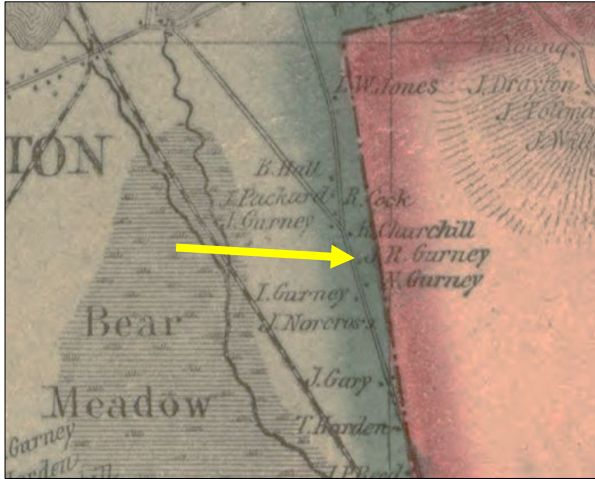
MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION

220 MORRISSEY BOULEVARD, BOSTON, MASSACHUSETTS 02125

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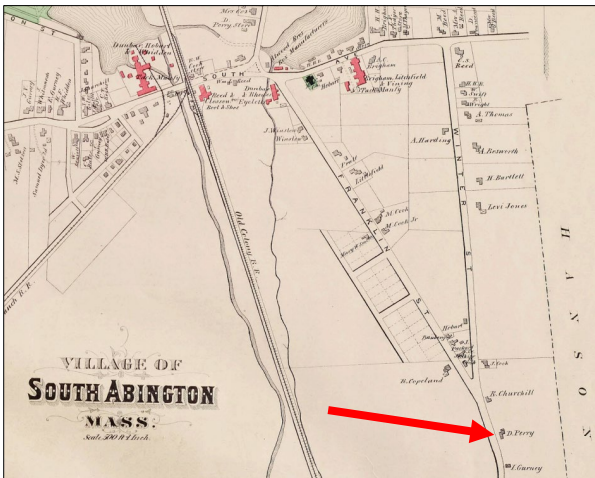
1914. However, a house appears on the 1857 map labeled J. [Jonathan] R. Gurney which corresponds to the house on the 1879 map labeled D. [Daniel] Perry, the husband of Lizzie Perry. In 1863 Daniel Perry, Jr. purchased a dwelling house and land from David A. Brayton of Fall River who had in turn purchased it from Jonathan R. Gurney in 1859.



1857 map.

Jonathan Reed Gurney (1792-1875), the son of Noah Gurney, Jr. and Molly Reed, was married to Deborah C. Reed (1795-1880) in 1816. The appearance of the house suggests that it was probably built by Gurney around the time of his marriage. His occupation was listed as teacher, grain merchant, and farmer in the 1850, 1860, and 1870 censuses, respectively. The 1857 map shows three other members of the Gurney family in close proximity to each other with the first initials N, J, and I. Jonathan R. Gurney was a charter member of the First Baptist Church in Abington and his headstone includes the honorific "Deacon."

Daniel Perry, Jr. (1820-1896) was listed in the 1870 census as a retail grocer and in 1890s directories as a grocer and coal dealer. He was first married in 1845 to Mary A. Hartwell (1828-1895); the couple later divorced. The 1870 census shows Daniel Perry, Jr. living in Abington with his father and a housekeeper, Elizabeth (Lizzie) Hatch (1836-1930), whom he married in November of that year. Lizzie Perry, who is shown as the owner on the 1903 map, sold the property in 1914.



1879 map.

The house was purchased in 1919 by Otis Churchill, whose 1918 draft registration noted his employer as the Commonwealth Shoe & Leather Company. The 1920 and 1930 censuses recorded him living in the subject house with a servant, Mabel Gay, and two lodgers. Churchill apparently never married. In 1934 the property was acquired by Ezra W. [William] Kimball (1883-1948) and his wife Helen Louise Baker (1889-1964), who owned the property until 1955. Ezra Kimball had a career in the telephone and furniture industries before moving from Chicago with his family in 1940 to Whitman, where he worked in shoe manufacturing. After the death of her husband, Helen Kimball owned the property with her son, E. William Kimball, Jr. The 1950 census lists Kimball, Jr., age 20, as a baseball player with the Alabama State League. He went on to play Minor League Baseball.¹ The property left the Kimball family in 1955.

Title Research

Date	Book-Page (Certificate)	Grantor	Grantee
06-29-1998	16346-342	John S. & Joanne I. Dee	Gregory C. O'Roark, Jr.
08-17-1972	3808-531	Frank F. & Ethel M. Fabrizio	John S. & Joanne I. Dee
03-02-1955	2402-351	Helen L. & Ezra W. Kimball, Jr.	Frank F. & Ethel M. Fabrizio
10-05-1950	2117-240	Elizabeth A. Barry	Helen L. & Ezra W. Kimball, Jr.
10-05-1950	2117-239	Helen L. Kimball	Elizabeth A. Barry
08-29-1934	1671-467	David H. Toomey	Helen L. & Ezra W. Kimball
09-06-1933	1648-328	Otis C. Churchill	David H. Toomey
09-11-1919	1333-479	Eliza H. Moore	Otis C. Churchill
03-23-1914	1074-435	Elizabeth F. Perry	Eliza H. Moore
06-13-1863	318-79	David A. Brayton	Daniel Perry, Jr.

¹ “William Kimball,” Baseball Reference.

INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

WHITMAN

364 FRANKLIN STREET

MASSACHUSETTS HISTORICAL COMMISSION

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08-20-1859	297-2	Jonathan R. Gurney	David A. Brayton
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"William Kimball, " Baseball Reference at <https://www.baseball-reference.com/register/player.fcgi?id=kimbal001e-->

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Assessor's card plan

INVENTORY FORM B CONTINUATION SHEET

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364 FRANKLIN STREET

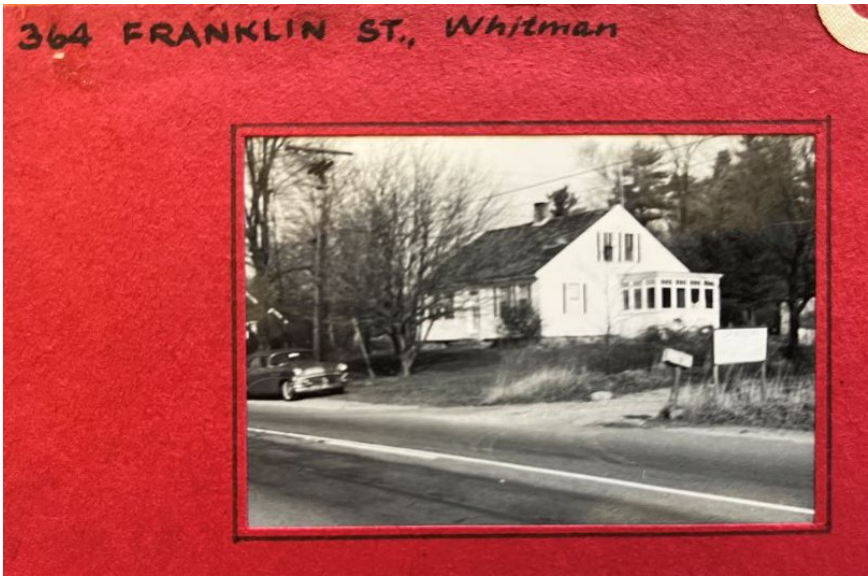
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North and west (façade) elevations.



Mid-20th century photograph courtesy of the Dyer Memorial Library & Archives.